# U.S. PhDs before and after ChatGPT

Research doctorate recipients at U.S. institutions | 2015-2025 | NCSES Survey of Earned Doctorates

## Question and scope

How did annual research doctorate counts change around the November 30, 2022 public launch of ChatGPT? This is a descriptive timing comparison, with a mathematics and statistics focus. It does not estimate an effect caused by ChatGPT.

| Survey year | All research doctorates | Mathematics and statistics | Math/stat share |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2015 | 54,886 | 1,815 | 3.31% |
| 2016 | 54,809 | 1,872 | 3.42% |
| 2017 | 54,550 | 1,844 | 3.38% |
| 2018 | 55,077 | 2,022 | 3.67% |
| 2019 | 55,597 | 2,010 | 3.62% |
| 2020 | 55,200 | 2,024 | 3.67% |
| 2021 | 52,158 | 2,010 | 3.85% |
| 2022 | 57,435 | 2,247 | 3.91% |
| 2023 | 57,801 | 2,165 | 3.75% |
| 2024 | 58,013 | 2,092 | 3.61% |
| 2025 | 59,015 | 2,175 | 3.69% |

## Period averages

Mean annual all-field count: **54,964** in 2015-2022 versus **58,276** in 2023-2025 (+6.0%). Mathematics and statistics: **1,980** versus **2,144** (+8.3%). The windows have different lengths; these are simple averages, not adjusted forecasts.

## How to read this

Survey year 2023 spans July 2022-June 2023 and straddles launch. A 2023-2025 graduation reflects admissions and research decisions made years earlier. The 2021 field taxonomy change complicates subfield trends; COVID, funding, and immigration also matter. Counts cannot show whether AI changed demand for a PhD.

Source: NCSES, Doctorate Recipients from U.S. Universities: 2025 Data Tables, NSF 26-326, Table 1-5 (Sept. 25, 2026). ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/earned-doctorates/2025. The accompanying repository contains the data, code, chart, and a fuller methodology.